

Lecture 11

Evaluating and Controlling Technology

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Evaluating Information on the Web:

- Expert information or ‘wisdom of the crowd’?
 - Information Overload: Lack of Correctness
 - Search Engines: New Dictionary, New Libraries
 - Lack of Expert Evaluation
 - Wisdom of the crowd - ratings by public of website
 - If millions participate, the results will be useful

Evaluating Information on the Web:

- Wikipedia:
 - Written by volunteers, some posts are biased and not accurate
 - Although anyone can write, most people do not
 - Those that do typically are educated and experts

Evaluating Information on the

- Wisdom of the crowd
 - Problems of unreliable information are not new
 - The Web magnifies the problems
 - Rating systems are easy to manipulate
- Vulnerable viewers
 - Less educated individuals
 - Children

Evaluating Information on the

- Responsibilities of site operators
 - Should identify user-supplied content
 - Make clear which information has been verified
- Manipulation of images:
 - Movies and videos use special effects to add creativity and enjoyment of entertainment
 - People can use technology for deception and fraud
 - Ease with which we can modify digital images and video
 - Faking photos is not a new phenomenon; more people can do it now because it's easy

Evaluating Information on the

- Writing, Thinking and Deciding:
 - New tools have displaced skills that were once important
- Abdicating responsibility
 - People willing to let computers do their thinking
 - Reliance on computer systems over human judgment may become institutionalized
 - Fear of having to defend your own judgment if something goes wrong

The "Digital Divide"

- The term digital divide refers to the fact that some groups of people (the “haves”) enjoy access to and regularly use the various forms of modern information technology, while others (the “have-nots”) do not.
- New technologies only available to the wealthy
- Access in rural and remote regions lagged behind the cities.

Evaluations of the Impact of Computer

- The Neo-Luddite View of Computers, Technology, and Human Needs:
 - Computers cause massive unemployment
 - No real need (We use technologies because they are there, not because they satisfy real needs)
 - Computers cause social inequity
 - Benefit big business and the government
 - Do little or nothing to solve real problems
 - Computers separate humans from nature and destroy the environment

Evaluations of the Impact of Computer

- Accomplishments of Technology:
 - Prices of food are down and raw materials are abundant
 - Real buying power is up
 - Dramatic impact on life expectancy
 - Assistive technologies benefit those with disabilities

Thank You